



“Everything Is Fine”

WAR AND OSINT

YEHOR SELIN

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Dedication

To everyone who lived through the war in Ukraine —
and to everyone who, one day, will grow up never
having to know it.

And, above all, to Alexander.

You showed me how to do it right — so I could stay
home, and you went. You always told me it would be
fine. That you knew your work. That you would come
home.

You helped me find time when you had none left for
yourself. This book exists because you did.

Rest now, my friend. We will not forget you — and
one day, by the sea, in a country at peace, my daughter
will read your name and know who you were.

A Note Before You Begin

This is a true account of years I would rather forget.

Where it was necessary, I have changed names and details to protect people who are still living, still working, still close to danger. A few names I have kept exactly as they were.

Alexander is one of them. He should be remembered by his own name.

I am not a writer. I am someone who watches for a living. But there are things that have to be written down by the person who lived them, in his own words, or they are simply lost — and some of them are too important to lose.

Contents

Prologue	6
Fifteen Minutes	8
The Man Who Gave Me Time	14
The Father	21
The One Beside Me	25
The House I Grew Up In	29
The Calm One	33
The Work	38
What I Build	43
A Night in Dnipro	47
To the Last Ukrainian	51
What I Still Believe	55
The Missing	60
She Will Read This by the Sea	64
What I Would Forget, What I Will Keep	69

Prologue

She knows the sound she was never meant to know.

She doesn't know her colors yet. She is only beginning to learn her words. She is one year and seven months old. But she knows the sound.

When we are walking, or just talking, and it comes — that low buzzing in the sky — she runs to me. She presses her tiny finger to her nose and says tss. Quiet. Then dzzz, and she points up. She means a Shahed. She knows what a Shahed is before she knows what a butterfly is.

Then she wraps her arms around me, and she begins to cry, and she says the only word she has for it: ba-bam.

She has never seen the world. She has done nothing to anyone. And she already flinches at the sky.

I am an OSINT specialist. My work is to watch, to track, to know where it is flying and what it will reach. I can read the sky in data before it arrives. And still — still — all I can do in that moment is hold her, and lie, and say: everything is fine.

This book is about that distance. Between knowing everything — and being able to protect no one.

Chapter One

Fifteen Minutes

We were asleep.

The day before, they had told us to be ready.

Not rumors anymore. That was the phrase that went around the office, passed from one mouth to the next, quieter each time. Not rumors anymore. Something is coming. I was still in the Department of Strategic Investigations then, and we had learned which sentences to take seriously. That was one of them.

But you can be warned a hundred times that the world is about to end, and your body will still not believe it. You go to sleep beside your wife. The room is dark and ordinary. Her breathing is the last ordinary sound of the old world, and you do not even know to listen for it.

And then you are awake, and it is gone.

I woke to explosions.

I went to the window. It is the oldest reflex there is — to look, as if looking could explain anything. I stood there in the half-light and could not understand what I was seeing. Aircraft, where aircraft should not be. Then a blast

somewhere across the city, and another behind it, and another.

The glass in the windows was trembling. Not breaking. Just trembling, steadily, the way a thing trembles when something far larger than itself has leaned against it.

I was not afraid in that first moment. I want to be honest, because this whole book is only worth something if it is honest. I was not brave either. I simply could not put the pieces together fast enough — the sound, the planes, the shaking glass — into the one short word they already spelled.

War.

Then my phone began to ring, and it did not stop. My chief. My colleagues. One call ending as the next was already arriving. Urgent assembly. Report in. And somewhere inside those voices, in the space between one call and the next, the life I had fallen asleep in quietly stopped existing.



I turned to my wife.

I heard myself say it, in a voice that sounded almost calm — the voice I would learn to keep for years afterward: Collect what you need. You have fifteen minutes.

Fifteen minutes.

How does a person fold a life into fifteen minutes? What do you take? What do you leave behind for the war to have?

She did not argue. She did not freeze. She moved. I will remember that as long as I live — how fast she was, how steady, gathering the few things a person grabs when there is no time to choose what matters.

We went down to the car. We drove. I was taking her to her parents — get her to family first, then go to work. The plan made itself; I do not remember deciding any part of it.

And on the way, through the windshield, I saw the thing I have never been able to put down.



People were standing at the bus stops.

Waiting for the marshrutkas, the little route vans, the way they waited every single morning, to go to their shifts.

Ordinary people. Ordinary jobs. On the first morning of the war.

The explosions were rolling across the city. The windows of the whole region were trembling. And these people stood at the roadside and checked the time, and none of it seemed to reach them. As if the sky were not falling. As if it were an ordinary Tuesday and the vans were merely running late.

I have thought about that picture for years now.

I do not think it was calm. I think it was something else — the mind refusing, in real time, to accept what the ears were telling it. The very same refusal I had felt at my own window a few minutes before, multiplied across a whole city of strangers.

We were all, every one of us, a few seconds behind the truth. And the truth was patient. It would wait for each of us to catch up, in our own time, in our own way.



I left my wife at her parents' door.

There was no time for the things you are supposed to say at a moment like that — and anyway, I did not yet know it was that kind of moment. None of us did. We still thought in days. A few days, we told each other. It will be over in a few days.

I got back in the car and drove to work, to wait for instructions, to begin whatever this was going to be.

For years I had learned to do this work the way I had watched the international professionals do it — patient, clean, from a distance. Investigations into people who would never know my name, in conflicts that were never my own.

That version of the work ended that morning too.

What I did from now on would carry a different weight. Different questions. Different stakes. The distance was gone. The subject of the analysis was the sky over my own family.

That was the morning my work stopped being a job in someone else's war.

That was the morning it became the war over my own home.

Chapter Two

The Man Who Gave Me Time

There are people who make you believe the world is still good.

Alexander was one of them.

He was the most human person I knew — and I knew it while he was alive. That is the part I hold onto. I did not discover his worth after, the way people sometimes do, once it is too late to tell anyone. I knew it then. I told him, in the way men tell each other such things, which is to say almost never out loud.

We shared the same dreams. Businesses we were going to build. A life we were both walking toward, just past the edge of all this. When two people carry the same picture of the future, they belong to each other a little. We belonged to each other like that.

Then, in 2022, my father stopped being able to walk.

First group. Paralyzed. The state has a category for it — a number, a line on a form. What the form does not tell you is what it is to watch your own father become a man who cannot stand without you.

I had left the police by then. I had no deferment from mobilization. And I needed one — a real one, lawful — for the simplest reason a man can have. Someone had to care for my father. That someone was his son.

If you have never lived here, I need you to understand something, and I will say it quietly.

Here, in wartime, a man does not simply walk into the recruitment office — the TCC, we call it — and calmly sort out his papers. You can go in to do everything correctly and not come back out. Declared fit. Sent on. The documents for a sick father set gently to one side. I had heard it happen. Not on the news — from people close enough that I had no choice but to believe them.

I was afraid. I will say it plainly. Not of the front. I was afraid of the wrong door closing behind me while my father waited at home for hands that never came.

And the man who stood with me inside that fear — who showed me how to do it right, who made sure every paper was where it had to be so the deferment would hold — was Alexander.

He gave me time.

I did not understand, then, what I was being handed. You never do.



He had no deferment of his own.

So he went.

I have turned that over more times than I can count. He spent his care making certain that I could stay. He kept nothing back for himself.

He was not afraid — or he never let me see it, which, with him, came to the same thing. I'm in my place, he would tell me. I won't die. What I do out there, I do well. And I believed him. You believed Alexander. He was good at everything he ever put his hands to. If the war kept a list of the men it would spare, his name belonged at the very top.

He bought his own weapon. With his own money, with his own hands — because that is what it has come to here, men paying out of their own pockets for the tools to protect the rest of us. He was using it to fight off the small drones. The

FPV ones. The kind built to hunt a single man.

That is what found him.



When they told me, I did not cry. Not at first.

There is a state that comes before grief, and my language has no clean word for it either. You simply stand still while the floor keeps moving, and you wait for the words to start meaning what they mean. I stood in it for a while.

Then there was work to do. There is always work. And mine — of everything it could have been —

was to gather the full data on his family.

My profession. The thing I am good at. The thing I am proud of. Turned, on the worst morning of all, toward the people Alexander loved most. I sat down and I did it — completely, correctly, the way it had to be done. My hands moved across the keys. The rest of me was somewhere above the room, watching a man work.

And when it was finished — when everything was where it needed to be, and there was nothing left that needed me — I

got into my car to drive home.

I could not see the road.

It was not the rain on the windshield.

It was the rain on my side of the glass.



There is one more thing. I have kept it for last, because it is the part I still cannot set down.

The day before he died, Alexander sent me voice messages.

He wanted to ask me for something. He needed my help with it — I could hear it in his voice. But he did not say what it was. I'll tell you a little later, he said. Later. When there was time. When things settled down.

There was no later.

He never told me what he needed. And so I never did it.

I do not know what he wanted to ask of me. Whether it was something small, or something that mattered more than anything. Whether it was something only I could have done. That door closed with him, and it does not open again — no

matter how many times I go back and stand in front of it,
listening to his voice ask for help I was never given the
chance to give.

Forgive me. For the thing I did not do, because I never knew
what it was.



Alexander.

I am writing this, and the tears have come again — here,
onto this page, years later, in a quiet room. I want you to
know that you are in a book now. That people who will
never meet you are going to read your name, and feel, for one
moment, the size of what was lost when we lost you.

You were my brother in everything but blood.

You gave me time when you had none left to give.

I will spend a little of that time here, on these pages, making
sure the world remembers that you were real.

Rest now, my friend.

Chapter Three

The Father

Before the war took everything else, another war had already begun inside my own family. It did not make the news. That kind never does.

My father was a strong man. The kind you lean on — not the kind who leans. For most of my life he was the fixed point, the one I measured myself against. We even competed over it, the way fathers and sons do. Who would earn more. Who would build the better life. It was a joke between us, and it was not entirely a joke. I wanted to win. And I wanted him to be proud that I could.

Then, in 2022, he stopped being able to walk.

First group. Paralyzed.

I have already told you about the morning the war began — the trembling windows, the fifteen minutes. This was the same kind of morning, except no one else felt the ground move. It was a second February, a private one. The end of one life, and the start of another, just for us.

The man I had spent my whole life measuring myself against could no longer stand without me.



He does not want to leave.

People ask why we stay. Why I do not simply take my family somewhere the sky is quiet. Part of the answer is lying in a bed in the town where I grew up. It is his home. His land. And there is a pride in him the illness never touched — he will not be moved from the place that is his. Not by Russia. Not by his own body.

So he stays in that house. And I carry a fear that has no solution.

Because a man who cannot move cannot run. He cannot take the stairs. He cannot reach a shelter. And when the alert sounds over the town where he lies, I am not there. I am here, in another city, watching the same sky on a screen — knowing exactly what is in the air above my own father, and able to do nothing about it.

That is the cruelest version of my whole profession. To know, in full detail, what is flying toward the people you love — and to be too far away to do anything but know.



I will tell you the one thing the war and the work never taught me. He did.

Patience.

OSINT teaches you speed. Decision. The cold, fast read. Caring for a man who cannot care for himself teaches you the opposite — the slow thing, the daily thing, the small unglamorous acts no one sees and no one thanks you for. Lifting. Turning. Waiting. Being there on the days when nothing happens at all, and the only war is the quiet one behind his eyes.

I was a man who was good at finding things quickly. He has made me a man who can also stay.

I do not know which of us is winning our old competition now. I stopped counting the money a long time ago.

I only know that I am still measuring myself against him. And I always will.

Chapter Four

The One Beside Me

I have written about the people the war took, and the people it broke. I have not yet written about the person who held the rest of us together while it tried.
My wife.



She carries her fear the way I carry mine. Silently. She almost never complains — and she has more right to than I do. She simply folds it inward and keeps moving, and unless you knew her the way I know her, you would think she was untouched. She is not untouched. She is only strong in the particular way this war demands: quietly, without applause, day after day after day.

I learned how strong on the very first morning.

Fifteen minutes — that was all I gave her, the morning the war began. Fifteen minutes to gather a whole life into a bag. And she did not fall apart, and she did not waste a second of it. She moved. That steadiness, in the worst minutes either of us had ever lived, is the moment I understood who I had married. Not someone who would need me to be the strong

one. Someone who would be strong beside me — so that neither of us had to fall.



She gave up things I do not speak about often enough.

A normal life. Plans. The shape of a future she had every right to expect. The ordinary things a young woman builds toward — they were quietly set down, one by one, so that this family could keep standing in this place, through this. She made no speeches about it. She simply made the sacrifice. That is the kind of person she is.

And I carry a guilt about it that I do not think will ever fully leave me.

Because I could not get her out. I could not put her and our daughter somewhere the sky is empty. For all my skill, for all my knowing, the one thing a man most wants to do — to carry the people he loves to safety — is the very thing I have not been able to do. She has never once blamed me for it. I blame myself enough for the both of us.



There is no grand gesture between us. No secret phrase, no special look that means we will be all right. I used to think there should be — something to hold onto, the way they have in films.

There isn't. And I have come to understand that the absence is the whole point.

Her reassurance is not a sign. It is simply that she is there. Every morning, every alert, every long night — still there, still steady, still mine. She is the thing that keeps me human. Without her I would have become only the cold half, the specialist, the man who reads the sky and feels nothing because feeling costs too much.

She is the reason I am still a person, and not only a function.

I tell my daughter that everything is fine. I tell my wife a little of the truth — not all of it, but some, which is more than I tell anyone else alive. And she takes that small piece of the truth, every single time, and she carries it with me.

No one should have to. She does it anyway.

Chapter Five

The House I Grew Up
In

I grew up somewhere else. Not in this city.

There was a house, in another town, and that house made me. In it were my father and my mother, my grandmother and my grandfather. Four grown people and one boy.

Whatever I am, I was assembled there.

Most of them are still in that house. The war did not empty it. It only put a sky over it that none of them ever deserved.



My mother is there, at my father's side. Theirs is the oldest promise there is — in sickness and in health — and the war has held her to the hardest half of it. She is the one who quietly worries for all of us at once, the way mothers do.



My grandmother and my grandfather are still alive.

Think about what that means. They have already lived through more than one hard age — the long grinding decades, the collapse of one whole world and the difficult building of another. They had earned a quiet old age. They

had paid for it, many times over.

And the war came for them anyway, at the very end, when they were owed peace more than anyone alive.

I have to tell you one thing about my grandfather, because it explains something about all of us.

When a strike lands near them, he does not hide. He goes toward it. An old man, walking to the place everyone else is running from — to pull at the rubble, to help whoever is under it, while the danger is still in the air and another one could come at any moment.

I have spent a career learning to move toward the things other people avoid — in my own way, from behind a screen. I used to think that was something I chose. Now I think I simply inherited it, from a man who never needed a screen to do it.



My sister is the one who got out.

She is younger than me, and she left a long time ago, for somewhere abroad. For years she came back often — the way

you do when home is only a journey away, and not a risk. Now, in the war, almost never. It is too dangerous here. And I am glad, genuinely glad, that she has somewhere safer to be. But glad and missing are not opposites. I can hold both at once. She is safe, and she is far, and there is a sister-shaped space at every table now that does not get filled.



That is the truth of what the war did to my family. It did not destroy us. We are luckier than many — we are all, still, here. It only scattered us. Thinned us out across borders and cities and the plain fear of the roads. We can still gather. But getting every last one of us into a single room, at a single time — the way it once simply happened, without anyone having to try — has become almost impossible.

And this is the part the speeches never mention. The war is not aimed at soldiers. It is aimed at exactly this. At houses like the one I grew up in — full of mothers and grandfathers, and the children who became whatever they are because of them.

Chapter Six

The Calm One

In my home, I am the calm one.

My wife sees it. My daughter sees it. With every blast that shakes the windows, I say the same three words, in the same even voice. Everything is fine.

It is the largest lie of my life. And I tell it every day.



The air-raid alert is always with us. In Dnipro it is not an event; it is the weather.

I wake in the morning and put the coffee on, and the alert begins. I drive to work, and it is sounding. I drive home, and it is sounding still. And the worst one — the one I have never gotten used to — is the one that comes at night, when I have just lain down beside my family, when the room is finally dark and quiet, and then it isn't.

You would think a person could get used to a sound he hears every single day. You do not get used to it. You only get better at hiding what it does to you.

It has changed me in ways I did not get to choose. My sleep is thinner now; I hear every alert even half-asleep, and a quiet night is never a promise — more often I wake again and again to the next blast, and lie there counting the seconds, doing the math I wish I did not know how to do. And it has reached into the daylight too. A child's balloon bursts at a party, and my heart slams, and my body is ready to run before my mind can catch it and say there is nothing to run from.

That does not switch off. I have stopped waiting for it to.



There are two men in me when the sky starts up, and they do not like each other.

One is the specialist. He is cold, and I need him to be cold. He reads the warnings as they arrive — the direction, the type, the speed — and he works out, quickly, where a thing might be going and what it might reach. He does not panic. Panic is useless and slow, and there is no time for useless things.

The other is just a husband and a father, and he is terrified.

The specialist picks up the phone and calls my family to tell them which way not to walk, which side of the apartment to stay away from, to lie back down and rest. His voice is steady. And underneath that steady voice, the other man is screaming — because he understands the one thing the steady voice will never say out loud.

That I can guess where it is going. But I cannot stop it.

A Shahed is not a ball you can knock away. A missile is not something you can stand in front of. When one of them arrives, it does not negotiate. After it, there may be nothing left at all. Not the building. Not the car. Not the person.

I know all of this with the cold part of my mind, in full detail, better than most people around me. And the knowing does not help the warm part at all.



I have never broken in front of them.

Not once. With every huge blast I say everything is fine, and maybe, better not to go and look, or better to rest a little longer. They see a man in control. They see calm.

I keep the rest inside. I have always known how to do that — it is, in its way, a kind of professional skill, the same stillness I learned in the work. The only person I tell the truth to is my wife, and even then, not all of it. Only some of it. Only sometimes.

The rest I carry alone. I think most men here carry something alone. We have simply agreed, without ever once discussing it, not to set our loads down in front of the people we are trying to protect.

So I will say it here instead. On this page. Once. Plainly. Where they will not hear it.

I am not calm.

I have never been calm.

I have only been quiet.

Chapter Seven

The Work

I should tell you what the work actually is now. Not the version in the job title. The real one.

It begins before I am fully awake. I reach for the phone before I reach for anything else, and I read what came in the night — what flew, where, what is left. By the time the coffee is poured, I have already been to the war and back. I drink it reading the rest.



People imagine OSINT as something cold and technical. Screens, data, a man behind glass. And it is that, partly. But here, underneath, it is something else.

When the alert sounds while I am working, I do not panic, and I do not wait. After this many years, I already know — by direction, by type, by the shape of the thing — where it has come from and where it can still go. The analysis takes seconds. I have done it ten thousand times. And the moment it resolves, before I do anything official, I call my family.

That is the real work. Everything else is built around it.



A report, for me, is not paperwork. It is my name.

It is reputation, trust, professionalism — the three things a person in my field truly has. I look at every detail as if someone's faith in me depends on it, because it does. One wrong fact, one identity confirmed too quickly, one source not checked a second time, and the trust is gone — and you do not get it back. That was always true in this work, long before the war. The verification of a human being is not a thing you are allowed to be careless with.

Because when you verify a person, you are holding something fragile. You can be right, and protect someone. You can be wrong, and ruin them. I have never let myself forget which of those is in my hands.



Let me tell you about one case. No names, no country, not a single detail anyone could be recognized by. Only so that you understand what the work itself feels like.

There was a man who believed he had disappeared.

He had been running a scheme — taking people's money — and at some point he did what everyone who thinks he is smarter than the rest eventually does. He deleted the account. Wiped the channel. Renamed what was left. And he decided he was a clean page now. That the past was simply gone.

But the past is never gone. It only stops being in plain sight.

I did not chase him. You do not chase, in this work. You wait, and you watch. I gathered the small things he had left behind and forgotten — a fragment of an old name; a date that surfaced in two places it had no business being; a habit a man does not change even when he changes everything else.

And then there was one detail. Small. He would never have looked at it twice. I look at exactly those twice — that is the whole of my work. And it pulled the rest together: who he was, where he was, the real person behind the "deleted" trail.

I remember that second. Not joy. Something closer to silence — the moment a scattered thing suddenly becomes a face.



And here is what the manuals never tell you.

In that second, I felt no triumph. I was sitting at a screen, and somewhere past the window a siren was rising — an ordinary night, like all the others — and a living person's face was looking back at me. Yes, he was what he was. Yes, he needed to be found. But there is a human being at the end of every trail, even the dirtiest one, and I have never let myself forget it.

That is the difference between someone who can search, and someone who can be trusted to search. The first one sees the target. The second one remembers there is a person on the other side — and finishes the work anyway. Precisely. Carefully. Without a single mistake.



I am very good at this. I say that the way you would say you are tall — without pride. It is simply true, and it is mine.

And on the worst nights, being good at it is exactly the problem. Because being good at it means I know more than the people I love. And knowing more, here, is not a gift.

It is a weight you carry to a telephone, as fast as you can, praying you are fast enough.

Chapter Eight

What I Build

There came a point when watching was not enough.

The war moves fast, and it moves everywhere at once. No person, sitting alone at a screen, can keep up with all of it by hand — the channels, the reports, the hundred small signals arriving every minute from every direction. I tried. You cannot. Things slip past you. And the things that slip past you at night are the very things you most needed to see.

So I did the only thing I know how to do when the world is too big to hold.

I built something to hold it.



I will not say much about it. Some of it is not mine to tell, and I intend to keep it that way. But I built a system to watch — to gather what was happening across hundreds of sources, to lose nothing, to lay a whole night out in front of me so that I could see its shape, instead of only the piece that passed over my own roof.

I have always been this way. I have never liked using other people's tools. Not out of arrogance — out of need. If

something matters this much, I have to understand every part of it myself. I cannot stake the people I love on a resource I did not build and do not fully control. When the cost of being wrong is a life, it usually works is not good enough.



But there was another reason, quieter than the rest, and it took me a long time to admit it.

It was the helplessness.

The worst hours of this war are the ones in which you can do nothing — where the sky is busy and your family is asleep and you simply lie there, a passenger in your own night. I am not built to be a passenger. Building was how I refused.

While the city held its breath, I made something. I turned the helplessness into a screen full of knowing. It did not make us safer — nothing here makes you safer — but it gave my hands something to do besides shake. And on some nights, that is the whole difference between a man who is coping and a man who is not.

I build because I cannot stop the sky.

Chapter Nine

A Night in Dnipro

Let me take you into one night. Not a special one. There is no such thing as a special one anymore. Just a night.



It starts with the alert. It always starts with the alert.

Then, if it is going to be that kind of night, you hear them. The Shaheds. That low, flat buzz coming in over the city — the sound my daughter learned before she learned her words. You lie in the dark and you listen, and you count, and you wait.

I can tell them apart now, by sound. A Shahed is one thing. A cruise missile is another. A jet is another still. I never wanted this knowledge. No one should be able to read the sky by ear, half-asleep, lying beside his wife. But you learn the alphabet the war teaches, whether you want it or not.

Then the air defense begins to work, somewhere out in the dark, and the sky cracks, and the windows do the thing they have done since the very first morning.

They tremble.



When a blast comes close, you already know the order.
Family first. Always family first. I make sure they are
breathing, that the sound did not belong to us. Only then do
I let the specialist come back. The work can wait four
seconds. I have learned that those four seconds are the only
honest thing about me at night.

And then I wait, in the dark, doing the one thing left to do.
Knowing.



The cruelty of it is that the sky does not aim at soldiers.
The strike that reached my own relatives landed on the home
of a priest. A man whose entire life was the opposite of war
— who had nothing to do with any of it, who had never
carried anything heavier than a prayer. There is no logic you
can lay over that. After a while you stop trying. The sky here
does not check whether you deserve it. It simply arrives.



And then, eventually, the morning comes. It always comes.
That is its own strange mercy.

The morning after a bad night has a particular quiet to it — a stillness that is not peace. Often there is the smell of burning somewhere on the wind. And everyone does the same thing, all across the city, without ever arranging it: we reach for our phones, and we check who is on the line. Who answered. Who is still here.

And then I do the thing I hate most of all.

I scroll through the addresses that were hit in the night, and I read them with my heart in my throat, praying I will not recognize one.

So far, most mornings, I have been lucky.

Most mornings.

Chapter Ten

To the Last Ukrainian

There is an old saying here. Money is for the rich.

Like most sayings, it is partly true and partly an excuse. But it has stayed with me through all of this, because the war did not fall on everyone the same way. It never does.



I want to be careful here, because it would be easy to be unfair, and I have no interest in being unfair.

I am not angry at people who have money. I am not angry at the ones who left. Every person in this world has the right to live, to be safe, to take their children somewhere the sky is empty. If you could get your family out, you should have. I would never hold that against anyone. I have wished, more than once, that I had been able to do the very same thing.

That is not where my anger goes.

My anger goes to one specific picture. A person sitting somewhere far away and safe — by the sea, in Dubai, in some comfortable country — posting to the world that we must fight on. To the end. To the last Ukrainian.

To the last Ukrainian.

It is easy to spend other people's children. It is easy to demand a war to the death from a balcony where no alert will ever sound, where no one you love will ever press a finger to their nose and point up at the sky.

That is the part I cannot forgive. Not the leaving. The leaving, and then the speeches.



People ask, sometimes, what war does to a country.

I will tell you what I have seen. It does not only take buildings and lives. It takes something quieter, and much harder to name. It takes a percentage of the humanity out of people. A large percentage.

The country split. Not into two clean halves — into a thousand small pieces. People became different. Harder. Quicker to judge, slower to forgive. And not only toward strangers. Toward the closest people in their lives. I have watched it happen between people who once loved each other.

So I have decided, for myself, what humanity is now. It is very simple. It is helping another person, whatever situation you find yourself in. That is the whole of it. In a time when so many have let it go, I have stopped treating it as ordinary. It has become the rarest thing I know.



I do not know if I will ever take my family to the sea inside our own country again — anywhere but Odesa, and even that, who can say.

I do not know if we will stay in Dnipro. I do not know if we will leave. The war goes on, and it does not share its plans, and so you stop making your own.

That is its own kind of theft. Not of a place — of the future. Of the simple right to say, next summer we will go here, or next year she will start school there. We have been robbed of the word next.

And still — when I see those posts from the balconies above the sea — I do not envy the sea. I envy something smaller than that.

I envy the silence.

Chapter Eleven

What I Still Believe

People assume a war either makes a man religious or kills his faith entirely. For me it did neither. It did something quieter. It sorted out what I actually believe from what I only used to say.



I am not sure I believe in God the way some men do. It is a hard question, and I will not pretend to an answer I do not have.

What I believe is closer to this. I believe in fate. I believe that each of us has someone, somewhere above, watching over us — a guardian of our own. And I believe that nothing we live through is truly random. Every person who crosses your path, every meeting, every small detail that happens to you — none of it is an accident. It is all there for a reason, even when the reason is hidden from us. Even when the reason is cruel.

I have to believe that. It is the only frame in which any of this holds together. It is the only way that Alexander's death is not simply a senseless tearing of the world — but a thread in something larger, something I am not high enough to see.

Perhaps it is only a story I tell myself in order to survive. But I have noticed that the people who survive are, very often, the ones with a story.



The war did change one thing in me completely.

I used to plan. I used to look years ahead — where we would live, where we would travel, the kind of life we would build. I was a man with a future laid out in front of him like a map.

I do not do that anymore.

Now I live one day at a time, because one day is the only honest unit of time we have left. To plan far ahead is to assume a tomorrow the war has never promised you. So I have stopped asking for tomorrows. I hold the day I am in, and the people inside it, and I try not to ask the sky for anything beyond that.



When I do ask — when I let myself want something — it is always the same thing.

It is not victory. It is not riches. It is not even an end to the war, though God knows I want that too.

It is simply this: that everyone I love stays whole. Untouched. Here. That is the entire content of my prayer, if it is a prayer. Keep them. Just keep them.



And when I let myself picture the first day after — the first real day of peace — it is always the same picture.

The sea. My family beside me. My phone left at home, somewhere far away, switched off and forgotten. And silence. A sky with nothing in it at all. The ordinary, impossible luxury of a day that asks nothing of me but to live inside it.

I do not know if that day will come. I am not high enough to see it.

But I believe, the way I believe everything else now — quietly, stubbornly, against all the evidence — that nothing in this life is for nothing. That all of it, even this, is leading somewhere.

It has to be.

I have decided that it has to be.

Chapter Twelve

The Missing

I have told you what OSINT becomes in a war. Now I want to tell you what it can still be.

Because if I left you only with the pain of it, I would be lying to you by leaving out the rest. And I have promised you the truth.



I believe in this work. Not as a weapon, and not only as a shield — as a force. I believe OSINT is one of the most powerful good things a person can learn to do. That with open eyes and patient hands you can find what is hidden, and that finding it can change a life, change a case, sometimes change the world. My skills are not only good for recording destruction. I have always known that. The war just made it hard to remember.

And then I was reminded.



I joined a team for a Trace Labs search — a few of us, working a real case of four missing people. Four hours. For four hours I was completely inside it, the way I am inside the

worst nights — except this time the thing I was racing toward was not a warning.

They were people. Four of them, gone. Families still waiting by a phone, somewhere, for any word at all.

For those four hours my skills were not pointed at a threat, or at a ruin. They were pointed at a door — at the small, impossible hope of bringing even one of them back through it. I cannot fully describe what that did to me. It was the same work. The exact same skills. And it felt like the opposite of everything the war had turned them into.



People write to me now and ask me to teach them. To show them how this is done.

I do. Gladly. Not to make peace with anything — I do not do it to heal myself. I do it because I want to, simply and completely, with my whole heart. I want people to understand that OSINT matters. That it is not a parlor trick or a hacker's game, but a real power — and that power, in good hands, does good.

If I can put a piece of that into someone else, and they into someone else again, then the thing I know how to do outlives me. It keeps doing good long after I have put it down.

That is the version of this work I want my daughter to find one day, when she reads about what her father did.

Not only the man who read the sky in fear.

The man who used the same eyes to bring people home.

Chapter Thirteen

She Will Read This by the Sea

I have already told you that my daughter knows the sound.
Now I want to tell you how she learned it.



It was an ordinary day. We were outside, walking, not far from home.

The drones fly low over Ukraine now. Low enough to see against the sky, low enough that you do not need to be a specialist to find them — you only have to look up. One came across the sky above us, and she saw it before I could decide whether to point it out or not. She lifted her small finger and said, dzzz. A sound for a thing she had no name for.

I knew it would pass. I always know; it is the one mercy of what I do. We were nearly home. I thought, she will forget this by morning, the way she forgets everything at her age.

Then the air defense caught it, almost directly above us, and the sky broke open.

Ba-bam.

She was looking right at it when it happened. She heard that sound with her whole small body, and she kept it. She did not forget it by morning. She has not forgotten it since.



That is the thing no one warns you about. It is not only the war that teaches her. It is everything that sounds like the war.

When a neighbor starts a lawnmower, she freezes, and her face changes, and she runs to me — finger to her nose, pointing at the sky, ba-bam, already crying. When a motorcycle passes on the street, the same. A moped. Anything with that low, rising drone inside it.

Her body has learned a lesson her mind is far too young to understand. She has been handed the fear without any of the things that are supposed to come with it — no explanation, no reason, no way to make it smaller. Just the fear, raw, inside a person who does not yet know her colors.



I think often about what I have not been able to give her.

I have not shown her our country. I never even finished seeing it myself — there were always more years ahead to do it in, I thought. I wanted to take her everywhere. To show her that Ukraine is more than the inside of a stairwell during an alert, more than a sound in the sky. There is so much of it she has never seen, and may not see for a long time.

And I have not been able to give her the simplest thing a father is supposed to give. A safe night. The plain, animal certainty that you can sleep in your own home, in your own country, and nothing will come for you out of the dark.

She is one year and seven months old, and she does not have that. I cannot give it to her. It is not in my power — and I am a man whose entire profession is knowing things, and this is the one thing I cannot fix.



So I will tell you why I am really writing this book.

Not for the analysts. Not for an audience. For her.

One day she will be old enough to read these pages. That is already more than this war wanted to allow — and if she can read them at all, then we will have won back something it

tried to take.

But I want more than that. I want her to read this book somewhere quiet. Far from here. By the sea — a real sea, a calm one — in a country that is finally at peace. I want her to read about the sound she once knew better than her own name, and I want it to feel impossibly far away to her. A story about someone else's childhood. A thing that could never happen to her — because she will not remember that it already did.

If she reads these words and has to stop, because she cannot quite believe the sky was ever something to be afraid of — then all of it was worth it.

That is the only ending I am working toward. The only one I will accept.

Chapter Fourteen

What I Would Forget, What I Will Keep

People ask why I keep doing it. Why I keep watching, keep working, keep carrying it.

It is, I think, a foolish question — though I understand why people ask.

I keep going because life keeps going. Because I have a family to provide for, to protect, to make smile at the end of a day that tried to break all three of us. In the end, when everything else is stripped away, the truth is very small and very plain. Outside of the people closest to you — outside your family — you are not really needed by anyone. They are the reason. They have always been the reason. There does not have to be a larger one.



I love this work. I need you to understand that, because of what I am about to say.

OSINT — real OSINT, the investigations, the attribution, the long patient work of turning scattered signals into the truth about a person — that is where my soul lives. I came up from inside real operations. I am good at it. It is mine.

But OSINT in a war is a different thing wearing the same name.

It is informational pain. And the cruelty of it is that you are not standing outside the pain, studying it. You are inside it. You are part of it. You read the sky, and you know more than the people you love, and then you have to race that knowing to a telephone — to warn them, to reach them in time, to be the one who knew, and to tell it fast enough to matter.

I love OSINT. I do not love it here. I do not love it like this. And I think only the people who have lived through a war — who have had to keep a cold mind and not make a single mistake in a report, while their own city was the subject of it — will truly understand that sentence.

The rest can sympathize. They cannot know. There is no pity that crosses that line. The only thing that crosses it is feeling — and you only come to feel it by living it, which I would not wish on anyone.



Sometimes I go back to 2021, in my mind, and stand in front of a door that is closed now.

There was a window then. A chance to send my family abroad, before any of this began. If I could return to that man — the one who still had the choice — I would tell him one thing, without a second's hesitation. Send them. Get them out.

And yet.

If they had gone then, everything after would have been a different story — one I will never get to read. And I have always believed that nothing in this life is random. Every conversation, every meeting, every job, arrives at its hour for its reason. I believe that even about the worst of it. I have to. It is the only frame in which Alexander's death is not simply a senseless hole torn in the world.

So I do not really know what I would change. I only know what I would say. And perhaps that is all going back is ever good for — not changing the road, only finally saying the thing out loud.



I told you, earlier, that this work can feel like a prison with no fixed sentence.

People who have been in prison can at least count down. We cannot. There is no date on the wall. There is only the war, going on, and the not-knowing when it stops.

So I have thought a great deal about what freedom would even look like, if it came.

It is not riches. It is not some grand victory I could announce from a balcony. It is almost embarrassingly small. Freedom is letting my wife and my daughter walk out the door to go for a walk — and not reaching for the news. Not listening for the sirens. Not running the sky in my head the whole time they are gone. Just letting them go, and trusting the air to be only air.

That is the whole of it. That is everything I want.



And when it is over — if I live to see it over — I will tell you honestly what I want to do with this entire period of my life.

I want to forget it.

All of it. The trembling windows. The fifteen minutes. The two men fighting inside me every night. The road I could not see for the tears. I want it gone, the way you want a long fever gone, leaving nothing behind.

There is only one thing I will not let myself forget. One thing I will carry on purpose, for the rest of my life, no matter how much of the rest I am finally allowed to put down.

The ones who gave their lives. For us. For this country. For a peace they did not live to stand in.

Alexander among them.

I will forget the war. I will not forget them. I do not think those two wishes contradict each other. I think they are the same wish, seen from two sides — to be free of the pain, and to keep faith with the people who paid for that freedom and never collected it.



There is one more thing, and then I am finished.

When the war ends, I am told, there will be celebrations. Fireworks, probably. Light thrown up into a sky that finally

means us no harm.

I do not think I will be able to stand under it.

I think I will hear the first crack of it, and my heart will do what it has been trained to do, and I will look for my daughter before I look at the lights. I think a part of me will flinch at the sky for the rest of my life, no matter how blue and empty it becomes.

But she might not.

She is young enough. If we get her to that quiet place — that calm sea, that country at peace — she might grow up able to watch fireworks and see only fireworks. To hear a lawnmower and think only of cut grass. To look up and find nothing there at all but the evening.

If that is the trade — that I keep the flinch, so that she can lose it —

then I will take it. Gladly. A thousand times over.

And when she asks me, one day, what it was like —

I already know what I am going to tell her.

I am going to hold her, the way I held her through every
sound she was too small to understand.

And I am going to say: everything is fine.

This time, finally, it will be true.